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Homelessness - Homeowners should get a say on 'cabin communities'

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"Location, location, location."

That's the well known answer to the question, "What are the three most important things in real estate?"

A home is the biggest investment most people will make in their lifetime. Buying a home typically requires a commitment of past earnings (savings) and future earnings (debt) stretching over decades.

If a neighborhood suddenly declines in value, people who sell their homes can end up losing their entire investment, owing the mortgage lender more than the selling price of the property. That's a painful memory for many people who went through the real estate crash of the Great Recession.

When people do everything "right" — stay in school, work, save, invest, make mortgage payments, pay taxes and more taxes — and then lose everything due to circumstances beyond their control, they have every right to be angry about it.

That's happening in the San Fernando Valley community of Reseda right now.

The city of Los Angeles is forcing residents to accept a "temporary" homeless "community," constructed at public expense, in a city parking lot directly across the street from a townhome development. By "temporary," the city means it will be there for at least five years.

This is only one of a number of "cabin communities" going up throughout the city. An Orange Line parking lot in Tarzana will soon be converted to a homeless housing site, another site is possible in Canoga Park, and two more will be built in North Hollywood.

Taxpayers get the bill, but there's a disproportionate financial burden placed on property owners in the neighborhood, people who have saved and worked to own moderately priced real estate in a quiet, residential neighborhood. These "cabin communities" are homeless encampments with walls. They could bring with them problems that a parking lot never caused.

According to city councilman Bob Blumenfield's website, the cabin communities "are directly related to a federal lawsuit about homelessness that is being heard by Federal Judge David O. Carter." The city is in the process of negotiating yet another settlement that purportedly will one day allow the local government to enforce a reasonable law against public camping.

This began with the Jones v. Los Angeles settlement in 2007, when the city agreed to stop enforcing a ban on sitting, sleeping or lying on the sidewalk until a specified number of housing units were constructed for the chronically homeless. The housing was constructed. The enforcement never resumed.

In the latest lawsuit, Judge Carter has ordered the city and county of Los Angeles to find housing for people who are camping within 500 feet of a freeway. This is the city's stated justification for spending $130,000 each for "cabins" to house people currently living at nearby freeway underpasses, and for forcing city residents to accept these cabin communities in their neighborhood parks and public parking lots.

There's no guarantee, not even a politician's promise, that the city will enforce a ban on tent encampments near

freeways or anywhere else once the cabin communities are constructed.

And more neighborhoods could soon be affected by the policy. Assembly Bill 3308, authored by Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel and signed by Gov. Newsom in September, appeared to be a proposal to allow school districts to build housing for teachers and school district workers on district-owned land. But then the bill was quietly amended to add the words “or other members of the public.”

What does that mean? According to the November-December newsletter of the Woodland Hills Homeowners Organization, the law allows school districts to “sell or swap the properties to outside developers” who could build housing “far denser and taller than most of the housing surrounding the site” and “could even use the sites for building accommodations for the homeless.”

This could be the future of LAUSD properties in Woodland Hills on Oso Street, Collins Street and Highlander Avenue.

Whether the cited justification is the pandemic, or a lawsuit settlement, or the high cost of living or some other reason, California residents have seen hotels, motels, parks, recreation facilities, parking lots and now schools transformed into homeless housing at tremendous public expense, with minimal if any public input, in a way that causes disproportionate harm to nearby property owners.

Expect pushback.

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